

County Council Meeting September 24th 2024

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GvsEKiZ_UYU
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Delaware County Council Meeting Summary

Meeting Date: September 2024

Report Publication: Civic Analysis Reporting Desk

1. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Presiding Officer Jessica Piper called the September 2024 Delaware County Council meeting to order at [00:00:14](#). The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance led by Mike Ashley [00:01:19](#).
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Council Members Mr. Web, Mr. Flanigan, Mr. M [Mull], Mr. Hughes, Mr. Whitehead, Mr. Camp, Miss Piper (President), and Mr. Freeman. (Note: Presiding officer and roll call confirm a full complement of council members in attendance).
 - **Absent:** None noted.

2. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** Included the Pledge of Allegiance [00:00:17](#).
- **Approval of Agenda:** Approved by roll call vote following a motion by Dan and second by Eugene [00:01:17](#).

- **Approval of Minutes:** August 27, 2024 County Council meeting minutes approved following a motion by Eugene and second by Dan, with a brief comment from the floor regarding expediting meeting minutes [00:01:38](#).
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3. Substantive Business & Board Action

- [00:02:18](#) **Transfer Request: County General Extension Office**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Presented via fund records (Office supplies negative \$640; repairs and equipment positive \$640; net zero). Representative Dustin was not in attendance.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussion arose regarding the absence of the office representative, as routine policy dictates tabling requests when representatives are absent.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Moved to table until the next meeting by Bill, seconded, and **Approved to Table by Voice Vote** (subsequently formalized via roll call vote).
- [00:04:43](#) **Transfer Request: Health First Indiana (Fund 1161)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Matt / Finance Committee notes (Department head Jamie excused due to attending the Association of Indiana Counties statewide conference).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Funds unspent from unfilled staff salaries are being reallocated toward equipment and contractual partnerships. Contractual funds support health partnerships (diabetes, hypertension, gun safety, Delaware County Prevention Council suicide prevention, Purdue Extension programs, tobacco/vaping education, and alternative-to-suspension programs with Muncie Community Schools). Equipment allocations fund building elevator repairs, second-floor A/C, security lighting/cameras, and signage.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion to approve by Ryan, second by Dan. **Approved Unanimously by Roll Call Vote.**
- [00:11:48](#) **Appropriation Request: Commissioners (County General - Health Insurance)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Commissioners / Sarah (via phone).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** An additional \$300,000 is requested for the health insurance line to address a shortfall in 2024 projections. Council noted that health insurance and utility cost escalations require budget adjustments moving forward into the 2025 budget.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion to approve by Ryan, second. **Approved Unanimously by Roll Call Vote.**
- [00:15:26](#) **Appropriation Request: VCA (Victims of Crime Act Grant)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** VCA Director.

- **Deliberation Summary:** Request for \$8,565 in grant funding (reimbursement grant) to cover staff salaries (child home and school visitors) through the end of the grant cycle ending October 1st.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion to approve by Ryan, second by Dan. **Approved Unanimously by Roll Call Vote.**
- **00:17:30 Appropriation Request: Capital Improvements (EMS/Ambulance Chassis)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mike.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Request for \$56,443 for capital outlays to purchase a truck chassis ahead of time to secure a purchase discount and hold a spot in line for an ambulance remount scheduled for November.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion to approve by Ryan, second by Dan. **Approved Unanimously by Roll Call Vote.**
- **00:18:53 Transfer Request: DC Fair and Expo**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Donna.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Transfer of \$22,000 for utility services (electric and water).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion to approve by Ryan, second by Dan. **Approved Unanimously by Roll Call Vote.**
- **00:20:19 Ordinance 2024-019 (First Reading): Solar Abatement Moratorium Ordinance**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Councilman Web / Ben (Attorney).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Introduction of an ordinance modeled after Wells County provisions implementing an indefinite moratorium on the filing, processing, review, and granting of tax abatements and other subsidies for large-scale commercial solar, carbon capture, or alternative energy generation storage facilities. Council members discussed legal nuances, the distinction between zoning authority (held by Plan Commission/Commissioners) and tax abatement authority (held by Council), and the receipt of a Baker Tilly report from developers. A motion to suspend the rules for immediate adoption failed due to lack of consensus; the ordinance advanced to a first reading.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion to open for first reading by Eugene, second by Bill. **Approved Unanimously by Roll Call Vote** for first reading; second reading set for next month.
- **00:43:08 Ordinance 2024-015: Job Descriptions & Salary Classifications**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Ben (Attorney) / Bill Whitehead.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Removal from table and consideration for final adoption as amended to take effect January 1, 2025. Council members debated lingering concerns from department heads regarding job description accuracy and FLSA exemptions, contrasted with the necessity of aligning job descriptions with the upcoming budget adoption on October 3rd.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion to remove from table by Bill, second by Eugene. Motion to adopt as amended by Bill, second by Eugene. **Passed by Roll Call Vote**

(Mr. Web voted "No"; remaining members voted "Yes").

- **00:50:03 New Business: Principal Planner Salary Rate (Plan Commission)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Ken Swackhammer (Plan Commission) / Kylen.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Request to hire a principal planner applicant at the proposed leveling rate of \$41.80/hr (instead of the vacant slot's lower rate of \$35.92) using existing unspent funds in the vacant position's line item. The position is 80% reimbursable from state transportation funds.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Motion to approve paying the principal planner at the leveling rate upon hire by Bill, second by Matt. **Approved Unanimously by Roll Call Vote.**
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4. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **00:50:48 Autumn Grismore:** Spoke in opposition to industrial solar farms, emphasizing the loss of prime farmland, lack of true local economic multiplier effects, and the displacement of agricultural productivity.
- **00:31:11 Doug Marshall:** Expressed opposition to large-scale solar projects and tax abatements, highlighting potential negative impacts on neighboring property values and rural community character.
- **01:05:35 Chris Music:** Addressed the council regarding local political candidate history and public accountability. *(Note: Presiding officer noted the platform is not a political forum).*
- **01:06:56 Ron Crouch:** Thanked council members for meeting with residents regarding proposed solar projects, shared personal accounts of solar lease solicitation letters in the Royerton area, and raised concerns regarding property value impacts and local opposition representation.
- **01:11:00 Mike Johnson:** Spoke against industrial solar developments, expressing concern over property value depreciation, quality of life, and comparative local employment numbers versus traditional farming.
- **01:14:27 Janet Garen:** Discussed national energy policy, federal renewable energy subsidies, and urged the council to deny tax abatements to heavily subsidized green energy corporations.
- **01:20:22 Stephen Hines:** Presented comparative acreage calculations for major local manufacturing and industrial employers versus the proposed 1,200-acre Gaston solar project, arguing that industrial solar creates minimal permanent jobs relative to its footprint.
- **01:33:34 Mallerie [Last Name Unclear]:** Expressed strong local opposition to industrial solar developers and urged the council to maintain strict regulatory hurdles.
- *Additional public input included written comments read into the record from Tim Nickam and Vicky Gasaway concerning grid reliability, battery energy storage system (BESS) fire*

safety risks, and agricultural land preservation.

5. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - The statutory budget adoption meeting is scheduled for **Thursday, October 3, 2024.**
 - The next regular County Council meeting is scheduled for **Tuesday, October 22, 2024, at 9:00 A.M.**
 - Voter registration deadline reminder: **October 7, 2024.**
 - Notice given regarding upcoming board and committee vacancy announcements at the next meeting.
 - **Adjournment:** Official adjournment voted upon and approved following a motion by Dan and second by Eugene **01:30:00.**
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